

AGES 6-8

YOUR FIRST VIDEO GAME

Imagine it. Draw it. Play it!

CHARACTER

LEVEL

RULES

PLAY!

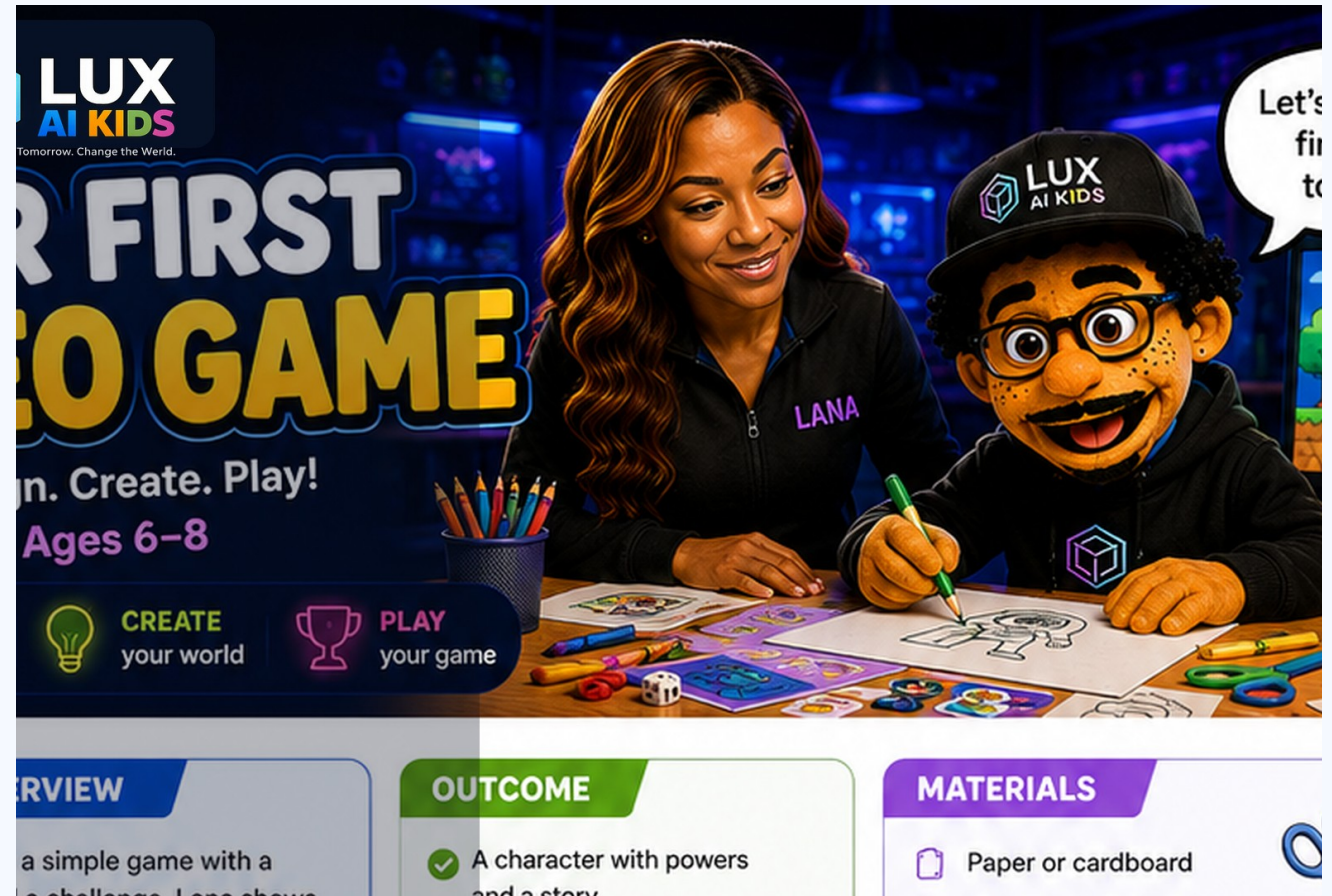
Build a hero, draw a level, make the rules, and test your own paper game!



TODAY YOU BECOME A GAME DESIGNER!

You will make five cool

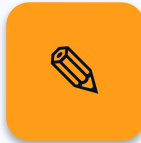
- things:
- 1 A game world
 - 2 A hero
 - 3 A level map
 - 4 Easy rules
 - 5 A better game after testing



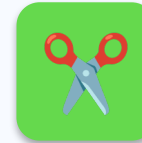
WHAT YOU NEED



**Paper or
cardboard**



**Crayons and
markers**



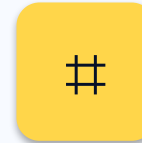
**Child-safe
scissors**



Index cards



**Stickers for
tokens**



A ruler

6 FUN MISSIONS

1

What Makes a Game a Game?

20 min

Every game needs a character, a goal, a challenge, and rules.

2

Pick Your Theme

15 min

A theme tells where the game happens and what kind of adventure it feels like.

3

Design Your Character

20 min

A strong game hero has a name, a clear look, one useful power, and a reason to act.

4

Draw the Board

20 min

A level is a path from START to GOAL with fun choices and challenges along the way.

5

Make the Rules

20 min

Rules make the game clear, fair, and possible to play without the designer explaining every move.

6

Playtest Time!

25 min

Game designers learn by watching real players and changing one thing at a time.

LANA'S AI HELPER PROMISE

AI can help with ideas. YOU are the game designer.

1

ASK A GROWN-UP

before using an AI tool

2

KEEP IT PRIVATE

no full name, school, address, or
face photo

3

CHECK THE IDEA

AI can be silly or wrong

4

YOU DECIDE

keep, change, or skip every idea

MISSION 1



What Makes a Game?

Character + Goal + Challenge + Rules

DRAW IT • BUILD IT • TRY IT



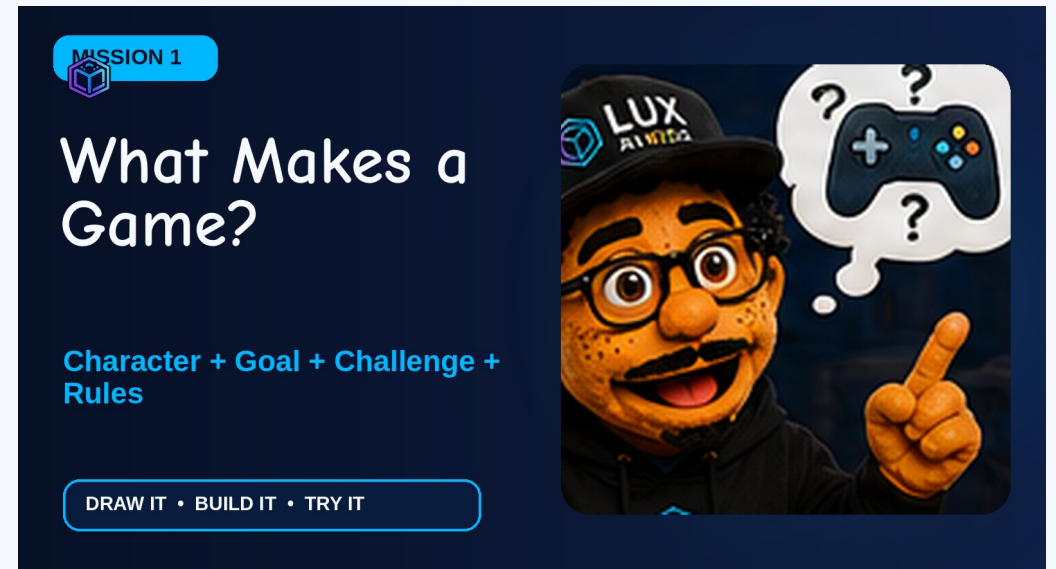
MISSION 1

What Makes a Game a Game?

Every game needs a character, a goal, a challenge, and rules.

ACE SAYS:

A game is a tiny world with something to do. A character tries to reach a goal. A challenge makes the trip interesting. Rules tell everyone how to play.



LET'S DO IT!

Game Recipe Sort: match picture cards to **CHARACTER**, **GOAL**, **CHALLENGE**, and **RULES**.

1 Show the four
Game Recipe
cards.

2 Say and act out
each part
together.

3 Use a familiar
game such as tag
to find the four
parts.

4 Kids place or
draw the four
parts on their
worksheet.

5 Invite two
children to share
their recipe.

Make: A completed four-part Game Recipe strip.

TRY THIS EXAMPLE

In a treasure game, the explorer is the character, the treasure chest is the goal, the river is the challenge, and “move one card each turn” is a rule.

QUICK CHECK

What tells the player how to win?

Answer: The goal.

ACE'S TIP Use movement: pose as a hero, point to a goal, step over a pretend obstacle, then freeze for a rule.

MISSION 2



Pick Your Theme

Choose the world for your adventure.

DRAW IT • BUILD IT • TRY IT

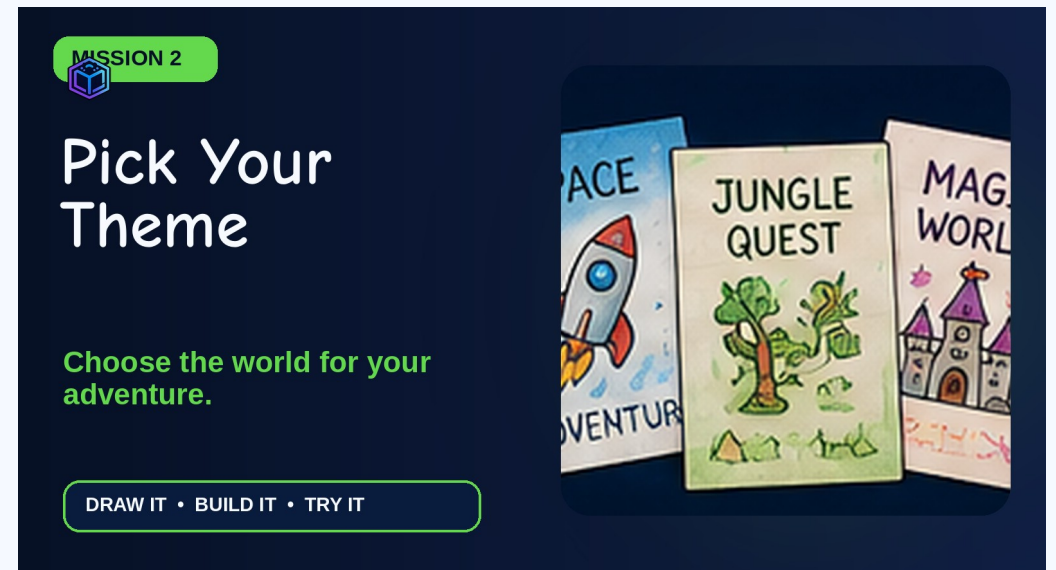


MISSION 2 Pick Your Theme

A theme tells where the game happens and what kind of adventure it feels like.

ACE SAYS:

A theme is the world of your game. It can be space, a jungle, the ocean, a magic castle, Dinosaur Land, Robot City, or a world you invent.



LET'S DO IT!

Theme Dash: choose a world card, then add one place and one mission.

1 Spread out the theme cards.

2 Let each child point to or draw a favorite world.

3 Ask: Who lives there? What could they need?

4 Complete the sentence: "In my game, the player will ____ in ____."

5 Give the game a fun name.

TRY THIS EXAMPLE

Theme: Underwater City. Mission:
Help a tiny submarine collect
three pearls and reach the coral
gate.

QUICK CHECK

**What does a theme tell
us?**

**Answer: Where the game
happens and what it feels like.**

ACE'S TIP Offer six choices, not twenty.

MISSION 3



Design Your Character

Give your hero one super power.

DRAW IT • BUILD IT • TRY IT



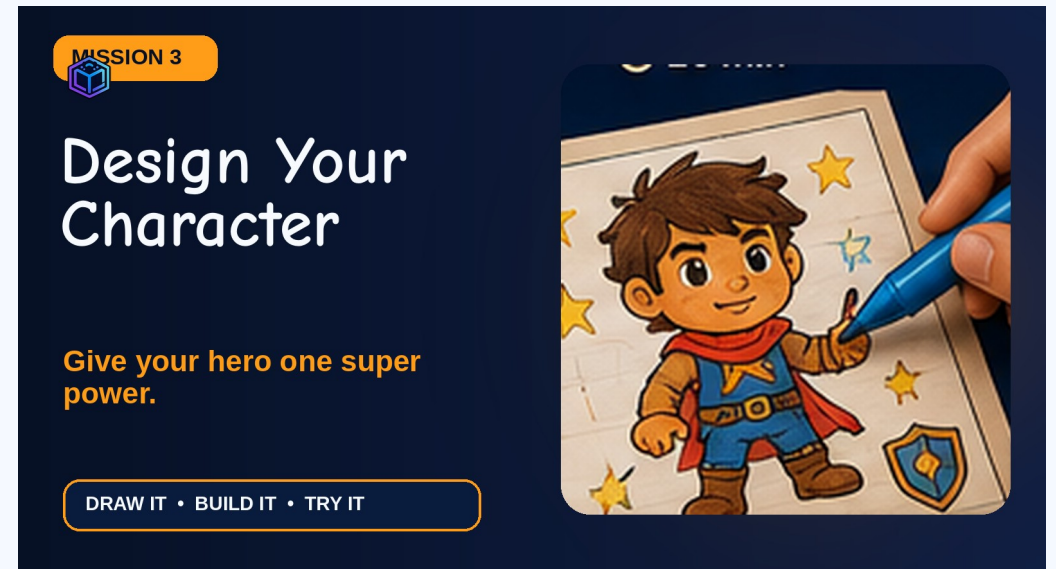
MISSION 3

Design Your Character

A strong game hero has a name, a clear look, one useful power, and a reason to act.

ACE SAYS:

Your character is the one the player helps. Give the hero one special power. One strong power is easier to understand than ten powers.



LET'S DO IT!

Create a two-sided Character Card on an index card: picture on the front, name/power/story on the

1

Pick a shape, animal, person, robot, or creature.

2

Draw the face and body with big simple shapes.

3

Add one color clue or special item.

4

Choose one power that helps with the game goal.

5

Finish: "My hero is _____. They can _____. They need to _____."

TRY THIS EXAMPLE

Milo Mooncat glows in dark caves. He wants to return a lost star to the sky before sunrise.

QUICK CHECK

Why should the hero have one clear power?

Answer: It is easier to understand and makes the challenge more fun.

ACE'S TIP Start with circles, squares, and triangles.

MISSION 4



Draw the Board

Start. Path. Challenge. Goal.

DRAW IT • BUILD IT • TRY IT



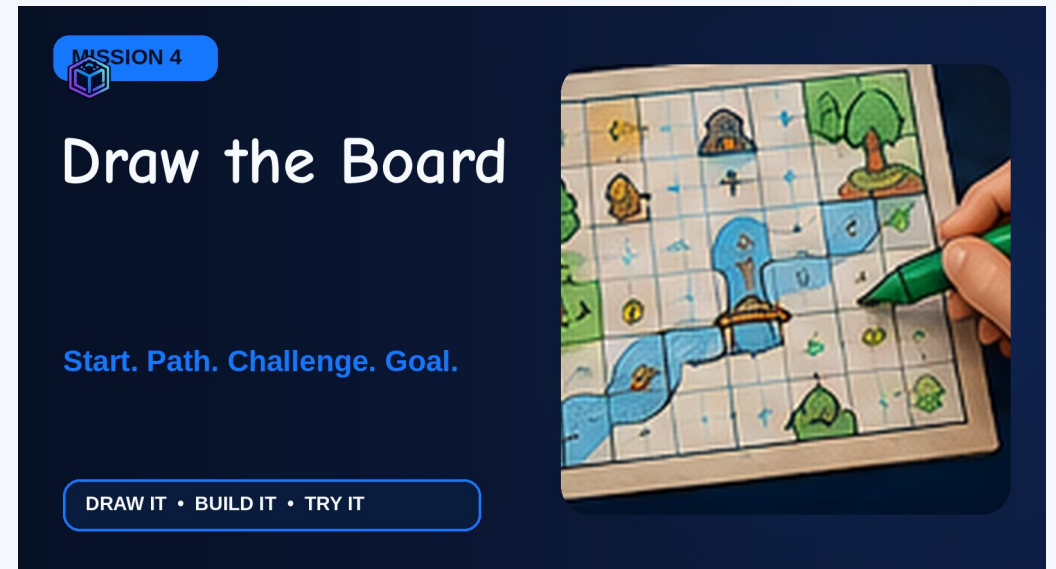
MISSION 4

Draw the Board

A level is a path from START to GOAL with fun choices and challenges along the way.

ACE SAYS:

Your paper board is a map of the first game level. The player needs a way to start, move, meet a challenge, and reach the goal.



LET'S DO IT!

Build Level 1 on paper or cardboard using a ruler, crayons, and sticker tokens.

1 Draw a large
START shape.

2 Draw a winding
path of 12-20
spaces.

3 Add one
challenge space.

4 Add three star or
bonus spaces.

5 Draw the **GOAL**
and decorate the
world after the
path works.

TRY THIS EXAMPLE

Start at the treehouse. Follow the river path. A broken bridge sends you back one space. Star spaces give another turn. The goal is the treasure cave.

QUICK CHECK

What four things belong in every level path?

Answer: Start, path, challenge, and goal.

ACE'S TIP Draw the path lightly in pencil first.

MISSION 5



Make the Rules

Make play simple, fair, and clear.

DRAW IT • BUILD IT • TRY IT

MY GAME RULES

Get to the treasure.

Watch out for the traps!

Collect stars for points.

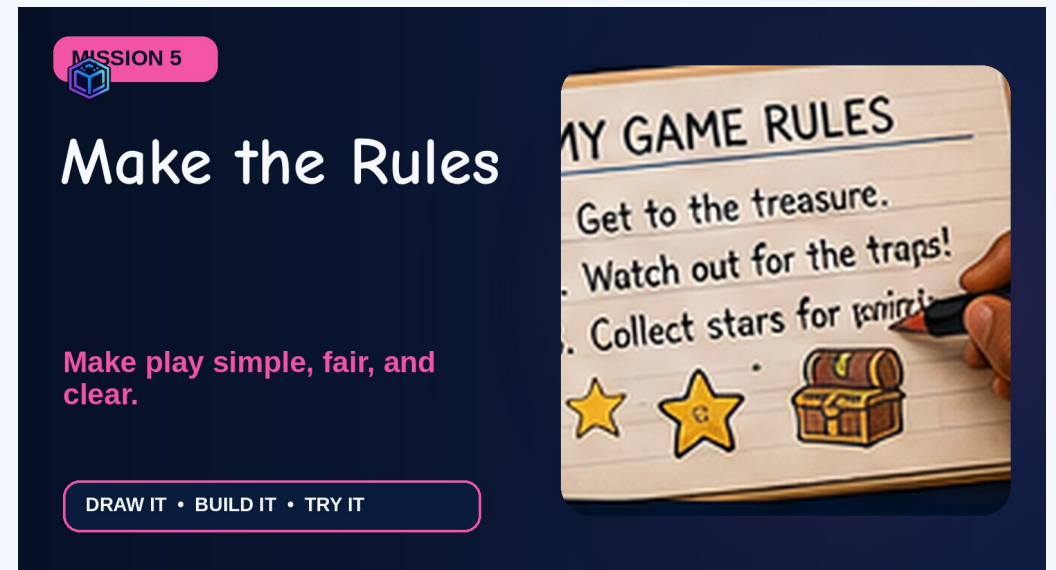


MISSION 5 Make the Rules

Rules make the game clear, fair, and possible to play without the designer explaining every move.

ACE SAYS:

Rules answer four questions: How do we start? What happens on a turn? What do special spaces do? How do we win?



LET'S DO IT!

Create a Rules Card and test the rules with a pretend turn.

1 Write or dictate
the start rule.

2 Make move cards
1, 2, and 3.

3 Choose what
bonus and
challenge spaces
do.

4 Write the winning
rule.

5 Read the rules
aloud and
remove extra
words.

6 With a grown-up,
build one
character-art
prompt and one
level-art prompt.

Make: A four-rule card, three move cards, and two paper AI prompts.

TRY THIS EXAMPLE

1. Put your token on START. 2. Draw a move card and move that many spaces. 3. A star gives one extra turn; a cloud sends you back one space. 4. The first player to reach the treasure wins.

QUICK CHECK

How do you know a rule is clear?

Answer: Another player can follow it without extra help.

ACE'S TIP Use short sentences and one action at a time.

MISSION 6



Playtest Time!

Play. Watch. Ask. Fix. Play again.

DRAW IT • BUILD IT • TRY IT



MISSION 6

Playtest Time!

Game designers learn by watching real players and changing one thing at a time.

ACE SAYS:

A playtest is not a test of you. It is a test of the game. If someone gets confused, that is useful information for the designer.

MISSION 6

Playtest Time!

Play. Watch. Ask. Fix. Play again.

DRAW IT • BUILD IT • TRY IT



LET'S DO IT!

Play, Watch, Ask, Fix, Play Again.

1 Pair up or make groups of three.

2 Designer gives a 30-second explanation, then watches quietly.

3 Players take a few turns or finish the game.

4 Ask: Was it fun? Was it fair? Was it clear?

5 Choose one change to make.

6 Play one more quick round.

TRY THIS EXAMPLE

A player keeps missing the bridge rule. The designer adds a bright orange arrow and changes the rule to “Bridge: go back 1.”

QUICK CHECK

What are the three playtest questions?

Answer: Was it fun, fair, and clear?

ACE'S TIP Watch where players pause or ask questions.

LANA'S ART PROMPT RECIPE

Ask a grown-up to type the prompt. Never share private information.

1

MAKE

a friendly game hero

+

2

LOOK

simple cartoon
shapes

+

3

COLORS

blue, orange, and
green

+

4

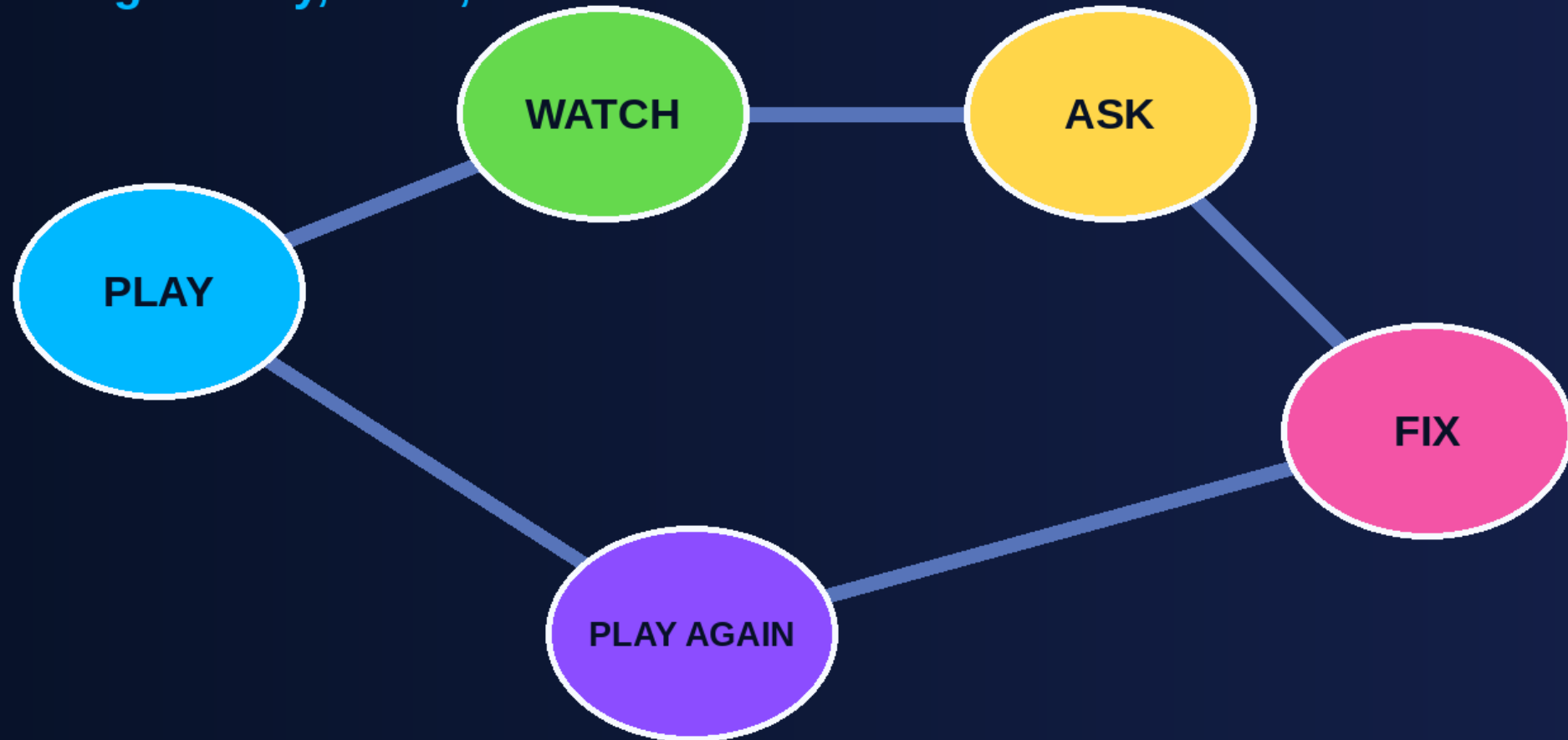
KEEP

no words or logos

“Create a friendly space fox hero, simple cartoon shapes, blue and orange, no words or logos.”

THE PLAYTEST LOOP

Game designers try, learn, and make it better.



FUN? FAIR? CLEAR? Change one thing and try again.

AI helps. People decide. Ask a grown-up first.

FINAL BUILD: MY FIRST GAME PACK

1

Theme and
game name

2

Character
card with one
power and
story

3

Level 1 board
with start,
path,
challenge,
and goal

4

Four-rule
card and
move cards
1-3

5

Two safe AI
art prompts
written on
paper

6

Playtest
sheet with
one
improvement

7

30-second
game pitch

SHARE YOUR GAME IN 30 SECONDS

My game is called...

The player is...

The goal is...

The challenge is...

The coolest part is...

NEW KIDS WORKSHOP



YOUR FIRST VIDEO GAME

Ages 6-8 • 6 fun missions • Paper prototype



IMAGINE IT. DRAW IT. PLAY IT!

YOU DID IT!

You imagined a world.
You built a hero.
You made rules.
You tested your game.

YOU ARE A GAME DESIGNER!

LEVEL UP!